KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER II: 1914–1960) ## QUESTION 6: THE LEAGUE OF NATIONS: COVENANT, STRUCTURAL WEAKNESSES & COLLAPSE

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2025 Q.3: 'Discuss the aims and achievements of the League of Nations. To what extent did its structural weaknesses and the policies of major powers lead to its failure?' 2018 Q.3: 'What were the causes of failure of the League of Nations?' 2016 Q.3: 'Discuss the mandate system and disarmament conferences under the auspices of the League of Nations. Why did disarmament fail in the 1930s?' 2013 Q.6: 'Examine the collapse of the League of Nations with specific reference to the Japanese invasion of Manchuria and the Italian invasion of Abyssinia.' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper II — Section 3: The League of Nations & Interwar Security (1919–1939) — Covenant, Successes, Structural Flaws & Collapse - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** The League of Nations was an unprecedented institutional breakthrough aimed at substituting traditional nineteenth-century balance-of-power diplomacy with collective security and international law; while achieving notable humanitarian and minor frontier successes during the 1920s, the League was structurally crippled by the fatal absence of the United States, the unanimity voting requirement, and the lack of an independent military force, ensuring its inevitable collapse when confronted by fascist aggression in Manchuria (1931) and Abyssinia (1935) amidst British and French appeasement.**

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • The Covenant & Institutional Structure: Established under Part I of the Treaty of Versailles (1919) at Geneva; composed of an Assembly (all member states, one vote), a Council (Permanent Members: Britain, France, Italy, Japan; plus non-permanent members), a Permanent Secretariat, and the Permanent Court of International Justice (The Hague). > > • Article 10 (The Core of Collective Security): Obligated members to 'respect and preserve as against external aggression the territorial integrity and existing political independence of all Members.' Article 16 provided for automatic economic sanctions and moral condemnation against any state declaring war. > > • Fatal Structural Weaknesses: > > 1. American Isolationism: The US Senate's refusal to ratify Versailles deprived the League of the world's greatest financial and naval titan. > > 2. Exclusion & Walkouts: Germany was barred until 1926 (walked out 1933); USSR barred until 1934 (expelled 1939); Japan walked out (1933); Italy walked out (1937). It became a 'league of victors.' > > 3. Unanimity Voting Rule: All substantive decisions in the Council and Assembly required unanimous votes, allowing a single rogue state to veto collective action. > > 4. No Independent Armed Forces: The League possessed no standing military, relying entirely on Britain and France, neither of which would risk war for collective security. > > • Achievements in the 1920s: Successfully resolved disputes over the Aaland Islands (Sweden/Finland 1921), Upper Silesia (1921), and the Greek-Bulgarian border (1925); Fridtjof Nansen's refugee passports; global eradication campaigns against malaria, leprosy, and human trafficking. > > • The Two Fatal Death Knells (1930s): > > 1. Manchurian Crisis (1931–1933): Japan invaded Chinese Manchuria; Lord Lytton's commission took a full year to report; when the League condemned Japan, Tokyo simply resigned from the League with zero punitive consequences. > > 2. Abyssinian Crisis (1935–1936): Mussolini invaded Ethiopia; League voted sanctions but cowardly omitted oil, steel, and the British-controlled Suez Canal; secret Hoare-Laval Pact exposed Anglo-French treachery in offering Abyssinia to Mussolini, completely destroying the League's moral authority. >

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1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

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WILSONIAN AMBITION (1919) THE 1920s ILLUSION OF PEACE THE 1930s STRUCTURAL COLLAPSE

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[Article 10: Collective Security]--> [Aaland Islands Resolved (1921)]--> [1929 Great Depression Slump] [Article 16: Economic Sanctions]--> [Upper Silesia Partition (1921)]--> [Manchuria 1931: Lytton Fails] [Permanent Council & Assembly] --> [Nansen Passports for Refugees] --> [Geneva Disarmament Fails (1933)] --> [Locarno Treaties & Germany In] --> [Abyssinia 1935: Sanctions Farce] --> [Kellogg-Briand Pact (1928)] --> [Hoare-Laval Pact: League Dies]

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2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **April 28, 1919 | Covenant Adopted | The Covenant of the League of Nations is unanimously adopted at the Paris Peace Conference. | | **Jan 16, 1920** | First Council Meeting | Council meets in Paris; US absent following Senate rejection of the Versailles Treaty. | | **1921** | Aaland Islands & Silesia | League successfully arbitrates territorial disputes between Sweden/Finland and Germany/Poland. | | **Oct 1925** | Locarno Treaties | Germany accepts western borders; 'Locarno Spirit' ushers in interwar era of reconciliation. | |**

Sept 1926 | Germany Joins League | Weimar Germany admitted to the League with a permanent seat on the Council. | | **Aug 1928** | Kellogg-Briand Pact | 62 nations sign pact 'renouncing war as an instrument of national policy' with zero enforcement mechanism. | | **Sept 1931** | Japanese Invasion of Manchuria | Japan seizes Manchuria; League appoints Lytton Commission; takes 14 months to deliver report. | | **March 1933** | Japan Leaves the League | Following League adoption of Lytton Report, Japan votes 'No' and resigns from the League. | | **Oct 1933** | Hitler Quits Disarmament & League | Germany withdraws from Geneva Disarmament Conference and leaves League to rearm in secret. | | **Oct 1935–May 1936** | The Abyssinian Crisis | Mussolini invades Ethiopia; Hoare-Laval scandal breaks; League sanctions fail; League collapses as security body. |

3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Noble Ideal and the Tragic Reality The League of Nations, established under Part I of the Treaty of Versailles in 1919, represented an unprecedented revolution in international relations. Championed by American President Woodrow Wilson, the League was designed to replace the secretive, balance-of-power alliance diplomacy that had precipitated World War I with a universal system of 'Collective Security' grounded in international law, arbitration, and disarmament. Yet, within two decades, this idealistic institution had degenerated into an impotent, discredited shell, helpless to prevent the relentless aggression of fascist dictatorships. In the historiographical debate, while Realist scholars like E.H. Carr condemned the League as a utopian delusion disconnected from the realities of military power, modern diplomatic historians like Zara Steiner and Sally Marks argue that the League was not fundamentally flawed in conception, but was sabotaged by critical structural handicaps, American abandonment, and the cynical, self-serving appeasement policies of Great Britain and France.

Institutional Architecture: The Covenant and the Mechanics of Collective Security The foundation of the League rested upon its twenty-six-article Covenant. Operating from Geneva, the League was structured around an Assembly representing all member states on an egalitarian one-nation-one-vote basis, an executive Council dominated by permanent Great Powers (initially Britain, France, Italy, and Japan) alongside rotating non-permanent members, a permanent international Secretariat, and the Permanent Court of International Justice at The Hague.

The ideological engine of the League was enshrined in Article 10, wherein members pledged to 'respect and preserve as against external aggression the territorial integrity and existing political independence of all Members.' If an aggressive state resorted to war, Article 16 prescribed automatic, escalating collective responses: immediate diplomatic ostracization, total financial and trade embargoes, and, if recommended by the Council, joint military action. The revolutionary concept was that an attack against any member state would be treated as an attack against the entire global community, rendering aggression mathematically irrational.

Structural Vulnerabilities: The Seeds of Institutional Paralysis Despite its visionary rhetoric, the League was crippled from its inception by fatal structural and geopolitical deficiencies:

1. The Defection of the United States: The fatal blow to the League occurred before it held its first session. In November 1919 and March 1920, the United States Senate, dominated by isolationist Republicans under Henry Cabot Lodge, refused to ratify the Treaty of Versailles. The absence of the world's greatest financial, industrial, and naval power deprived the League of the essential economic muscle required to make sanctions effective.

2. The 'League of Victors' and Pariah States: The League was perceived globally as an instrument designed to preserve the imperialist spoils of Britain and France. Defeated Germany was excluded until 1926, while Bolshevik Russia was treated as a revolutionary pariah until 1934. When totalitarian regimes ascended, they simply walked out: Germany and Japan resigned in 1933, and Italy followed in 1937.

3. The Unanimity Rule: Articles 5 and 15 mandated that all substantive resolutions in both the Assembly and the Council required unanimous consent. This absurd requirement meant that a single dissenting vote could paralyze the entire international community.

4. The Absence of Military Enforcement: The League possessed no standing international police force or army. To enforce Article 16 militarily, it relied entirely on the voluntary military contributions of its members. Britain and France, traumatized by the bloodbath of 1914–1918 and prioritizing domestic imperial defense, were adamantly unwilling to shed blood for collective security in distant theaters.

The Illusion of Peace: Successes and Humanitarian Triumphs in the 1920s During its first decade, the League achieved notable, albeit minor, successes that fostered an illusion of durable international harmony. In 1921, the League successfully mediated the bitter

territorial dispute between Sweden and Finland over the Aaland Islands, awarding sovereignty to Finland with guaranteed cultural autonomy for the Swedish inhabitants. In the same year, it peacefully partitioned Upper Silesia between Germany and Poland. In 1925, when Greek forces invaded Bulgaria in the 'War of the Stray Dog,' the Council acted decisively, ordering a ceasefire and compelling Greece to withdraw and pay reparations.

Furthermore, the League's specialized non-political agencies performed heroic pioneering work. The High Commission for Refugees, led by Norwegian explorer Fridtjof Nansen, created the historic 'Nansen Passport,' providing legal identity and resettlement to over 450,000 stateless refugees. The Health Organization orchestrated international campaigns that checked typhus epidemics in Eastern Europe and eliminated yellow fever, while other commissions combated human trafficking, regulated drug smuggling, and established the International Labor Organization (ILO) to elevate global labor standards.

The Acid Test of the 1930s: The Manchurian Catastrophe (1931–1933) The fragile security edifice built in the 1920s was shattered by the Wall Street Crash of 1929 and the Great Depression. In September 1931, the Japanese Kwantung Army staged the Mukden Incident, invading and conquering the vast Chinese province of Manchuria to create the puppet state of Manchukuo. For the first time, a permanent member of the League Council had committed unprovoked aggression against another League member.

China immediately appealed to the League under Article 11. The League responded with agonizing paralysis. Rather than imposing immediate economic sanctions under Article 16, the Council dispatched a fact-finding commission led by British diplomat Lord Lytton. It took the Lytton Commission fourteen months to travel to China, draft its report, and present it to the Assembly. When the League finally adopted the report in February 1933, condemning Japanese aggression, Japanese delegate Yosuke Matsuoka delivered a defiant speech, led his delegation out of the hall, and Japan formally resigned from the League in March. The League took zero punitive action: Britain and France refused to impose naval blockades or economic embargoes fearing Japanese retaliation against Hong Kong and Indochina. The message to the world's dictators was unmistakable: the League was an empty paper tiger.

The Death Knell: Abyssinia and the Treachery of Hoare-Laval (1935–1936) If Manchuria wounded the League, the Abyssinian Crisis was its executioner. In October 1935, Benito Mussolini's Fascist Italy invaded the sovereign, independent African empire of Abyssinia (Ethiopia), employing mustard poison gas, aerial bombardment, and armored divisions against defenseless tribesmen. Abyssinian Emperor Haile Selassie appeared personally before the League Assembly in Geneva, delivering an immortal indictment: 'It is collective security: it is the very existence of the League of Nations... It is international morality that is at stake. God and history will remember your judgment.'

The League declared Italy an aggressor and voted to impose economic sanctions. However, terrified of alienating Mussolini and driving him into an alliance with Adolf Hitler, British Foreign Secretary Samuel Hoare and French Premier Pierre Laval engineered a cowardly compromise. Sanctions were deliberately neutered: vital commodities such as oil, coal, and steel were exempted, and the British government refused to close the Suez Canal to Italian troopships. The final moral betrayal occurred in December 1935 when the secret 'Hoare-Laval Pact' was leaked to the French press, revealing that Britain and France had secretly agreed to partition two-thirds of Abyssinia to Mussolini behind the League's back. The resulting public fury forced Hoare's resignation, but the damage was irreversible: Italy conquered Addis Ababa in May 1936, annexed Ethiopia, and walked out of the League to form the Rome-Berlin Axis with Hitler. The League of Nations was dead as a credible security instrument.

Conclusion: The Legacy of a Visionary Failure In conclusion, the collapse of the League of Nations was not a failure of the principle of collective security, but a tragic failure of national statesmanship. Entrusted to the custody of Britain and France, the League was repeatedly subordinated to short-sighted imperial self-interest and the cowardly evasions of appeasement. When Adolf Hitler witnessed the League's total humiliation in Abyssinia, he promptly remilitarized the Rhineland in March 1936, confident that the Western democracies would never take up arms for international law. The League spent its final years in ghost-like irrelevance, meeting in Geneva while Europe slid into World War II. Yet, the tragedy of the League was not entirely in vain: when the Allied Powers convened at San Francisco in 1945 to establish the United Nations, they corrected the League's structural flaws by eliminating the unanimity rule, creating an executive Security Council with enforcement teeth, and ensuring the permanent institutional leadership of the United States.

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4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **E.H. Carr | The Twenty Years' Crisis (1939) | 'The fatal mistake of the champions of the League was to confuse an ideal aspiration with political reality... They believed that public opinion and moral declarations could substitute for military power.' | | **Zara Steiner** | The Lights That Failed (2005) | 'The League was an astonishingly successful experiment in international administration and multilateral**

diplomacy... It failed in the 1930s not because of institutional design, but because the Great Depression tore apart the international economic order.' | | **F.P. Walters | A History of the League of Nations | 'The League was not a super-state; it was an association of sovereign governments. Its failures were not the failures of the Covenant, but the failures of the statesmen of London and Paris to honor their solemn pledges.' | | **Haile Selassie (1936)** | Speech to League of Nations Assembly | 'I ask the fifty-two nations who have given the Ethiopian people a promise to help them: what are you going to do for Ethiopia? It is collective security that is at stake... It is us today. It will be you tomorrow.' |**